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Here's an update on the bills we're watching + Weber runs for Atkins' Senate seat

April 10, 2023 | Sacramento Bee, The: Web Edition Articles (CA)
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OpenURL Link

Good morning and welcome to the A.M. Alert!

WHERE ARE THEY NOW? A ROUNDUP OF BILLS WE'RE WATCHING

As lawmakers return from spring break, it's time to look at some of the most notable legislation being considered and where those bills stand.

We start with SB X1-2, by Sen. Nancy Skinner, D-Berkeley. What began as a plan to impose stiff penalties on oil and gas companies caught price gouging morphed into a bill to collect information from the industry and possibly set a profits cap.

That change was enough to ensure passage in both houses of the Legislature, and Newsom has since signed it into law. Not every Democrat was on board though. Assemblywoman Jasmeet Bains, D-Delano, whose Kern County district sits in California's oil patch, was the sole Democrat to vote no. That cost her a seat on the Assembly Business and Professions Committee.

And then there's SB 253, by Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, and AB 30, by Assemblyman Chris Ward, D-San Diego.

SB 253 requires corporations with at least $1 billion in revenue that do business in the state to report their annual greenhouse gas emissions to the public. That bill is in the Senate Judiciary Committee, with a hearing set for April 18.

AB 30, which creates a program to forecast and track atmospheric rivers — like the ones that pummeled California with rain this winter — is sitting in the Assembly Appropriations Committee.

Sen. Lena Gonzalez, D-Long Beach, has introduced SB 252 to divest California's pension funds from the fossil fuel industry. It is set to be heard Wednesday by the Senate Labor, Public Employment and Retirement Committee.

AB 460, by Assemblywoman Rebecca Bauer-Kahan, D-Orinda, to empower the State Water Resources and Control Board to investigate water rights is scheduled to be heard in the Assembly Water, Parks and Wildlife Committee on April 18.

AB 538, by Assemblyman Chris Holden, D-Pasadena, which would spell out how utilities can join a multi-state power line network, is scheduled to be heard by the Assembly Utilities and Energy Committee on April 26.

Housing is a big issue this session (when isn't it?), and lawmakers are considering a number of bills aimed at easing the state's affordable housing crisis.

Sen. Wiener has introduced a couple of bills on this front — SB 4 and SB 423.

SB 4 clears the way for churches and nonprofit colleges to build housing on the properties they own. SB 423 makes it easier for multi-family housing to get built but also requires developers to pay prevailing wages for projects with 10 units or more. Both bills are currently before the Senate Governance and Finance Committee.

Assemblywoman Luz Rivas, D-San Fernando Valley has introduced AB 799 to create an accountability framework for

cities receiving state funds to address homelessness. It is set to be heard by the Assembly Housing and Community Development Committee on April 26.

A guaranteed income program for homeless high school seniors is the focus of SB 333 by Sen. Dave Cortese, D-San Jose. It has been amended so that it starts in 2025 rather than 2024. It's in the Senate Human Services Committee.

The proposed wealth tax by Assemblyman Alex Lee, D-San Jose, AB 259, has been referred to the Assembly Revenue and Taxation Committee but has no set hearing yet.

Will California restrict the use of solitary confinement in its jails and prisons? Gov. Gavin Newsom vetoed the previous attempt, but AB 280 by Assemblyman Holden is making its way through the Assembly, now sitting in Assembly Appropriations.

ACA 4, by Assemblyman Isaac G. Bryan, D-Los Angeles, a proposed constitutional amendment granting people serving time for felonies the right to vote, is set to be heard by the Assembly Elections Committee on April 19.

Sen. Steven Bradford, D-Gardena, has introduced SB 50 to cut down on police traffic stops for minor offenses such as vehicle registration issues, window tinting or a single non-working brakelight. It is being reviewed by the Senate Appropriations Committee.

While Florida just became the latest state to allow concealed carry of firearms without a permit, California is heading decidedly in the other direction. Sen. Anthony Portantino, D-Burbank, has introduced SB 2 to make it more difficult to get a concealed carry permit and to limit where people can carry in public. It is set to be heard by Senate Appropriations on Monday.

AB 28, from Assemblyman Jesse Gabriel, D-Woodland Hills, would impose an excise tax on firearm and ammunition sales. That bill has been updated to include specific provisions: an 11% excise tax, with proceeds going to a new Gun Violence Prevention, Healing, and Recovery Fund. It is set to be heard Tuesday by the Assembly Public Safety Committee.

AB 315, by Assemblywoman Bauer-Kahan, would prohibit crisis pregnancy centers from falsely advertising that they offer abortion services or referrals. It has been referred to Assembly Appropriations.

AB 223, by Assemblyman Ward, seals petitions and related court paperwork for transgender youths changing their gender designation or sex identifiers. The bill has made it to the Senate, where it has been referred to the Senate Rules Committee for assignment.

AB 1314, by Assemblyman Bill Essayli, R-Riverside, which requires school employees to out transgender students to their parents, is currently sitting in the Assembly Education Committee with no set hearing date.

SB 287, Sen. Skinner's bill to hold social media companies accountable for children who gain access to ghost guns, fentanyl, harmful diet products, or content promoting suicide, eating disorders or social media addiction, is set to be heard in the Senate Judiciary Committee on Tuesday.

California won't be phasing out tobacco sales for young people just yet.

Assemblyman Damon Connolly, D-San Rafael, announced Friday that AB 935 has been amended to empower the California Attorney General's Office and the California Department of Public Health to enforce the state's flavored tobacco ban, which has generated confusion among retailers. That bill is being heard by the Assembly Health Committee on Tuesday. Connolly has vowed to bring his phased tobacco ban proposal back next year.

Another ban proposal — to order the app TikTok removed from all state-issued smartphones — is proceeding apace, with SB 74, by Sen. Bill Dodd, D-Napa, sitting in the Senate Governmental Organization Committee. A hearing set for April 25. AB 227, by Assemblywoman Kate Sanchez, R-Temecula, is currently sitting in the Assembly

Privacy and Consumer Protection Committee with no scheduled hearing date.

It wouldn't be a legislative session without some union-backed bills in the mix.

AB 1228, by Assemblyman Holden, would hold franchisors — the corporations like McDonalds — jointly liable for any legal violations committed by their franchisees — the people who own and operate the individual stores. That bill is set to be heard by the Assembly Labor and Employment Committee on Wednesday.

AB 1, by Assemblywoman Tina McKinnor, D-Inglewood, allows legislative staffers to form a union. It is in the Assembly Public Employment and Retirement Committee with no scheduled hearing.

And finally, we have SB 476, by Sen. Monique Limón, D-Santa Barbara, that requires employers to pay their workers for the cost of getting a food handler's card. It is in Senate Appropriations and will be heard on Monday.

WEBER ANNOUNCES SHE'S RUNNING TO REPLACE ATKINS

Assemblywoman Akilah Weber, D-San Diego, has announced that she is running to replace outgoing Senate President pro Tem Toni Atkins, D-San Diego, in 2024.

Weber, the daughter of California Secretary of State Shirley Weber, has served in the Assembly since 2021, when she was elected to the seat vacated by her mother (following the senior Weber's appointment by California Gov. Gavin Newsom).

Weber's announcement didn't happen in a political vacuum — it came after (now former) San Diego County Supervisor Nathan Fletcher, also a Democrat, dropped out of the race in a cloud of scandal.

In a statement released last week, Weber touted her record as a lawmaker: "As an Assemblymember, I have successfully fought to improve access to quality healthcare, strengthen our education system, protect our environment, and further economic prosperity."

Weber's announcement leaves an opening for her Assembly seat, and one candidate wasted little time making his announcement.

La Mesa Vice Mayor Colin Parent, a Democrat, announced he is running to replace her.

Parent is endorsed by Democratic Assemblymembers David Alvarez, Chris Ward and Tasha Boerner Horvath.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

"We are in solidarity with the two courageous brothers exercising their First Amendment right. We would have taken the same approach in representing the people's voices. Yesterday's expulsion of Tennessee lawmakers Reps. (Justin) Jones and (Justin) Pearson show that we still have a long way to go when it comes to our democracy and advocating for what is right for Black lives."

- Sen. Steven Bradford, D-Gardena, speaking as vice-chair of the California Legislative Black Caucus in response to the Tennessee Legislature's vote to expel two Black lawmakers who participated in a gun control protest.

Best of The Bee:

Some college students who were once automatically eligible for California's food benefits program will now have to apply before June 10. State officials are urging college students to apply for government assistance as soon as possible, via Sawsan Morrar.Gov. Gavin Newsom declared last month that California was "done" doing business with Walgreens after the pharmacy chain said it would not distribute an abortion pill in 21 states where Republicans threatened legal action. Since then, KHN has learned that the Democratic governor must compromise on his hard-

line tweet, via Samantha Young, Kaiser Health News.Northern California Congressman Doug LaMalfa waded into the debate over whether schools should be required to disclose to parents that their child is transgender, via Andrew Sheeler.One year later, Sacramento’s deadliest mass shooting continues to shape discussions in the California Capitol. They revolve around one question: would lives have been saved if one of the suspects had served out his full prison sentence? Via Lindsey Holden.Almost 10,000 child care providers have reached out to Gov. Gavin Newsom’s office demanding an update on the hundreds of thousands of dollars that the state promised them, via Jenavieve Hatch.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Sheeler, A. (2023, April 10). Here’s an update on the bills we’re watching + Weber runs for Atkins’ Senate seat*Sacramento Bee, The: Web Edition Articles (CA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/190D02F85B7DDB68.